

Basic Principle of Medicine II
Nervous System & Behavioral Sciences

Defense Mechanisms

(Directed Learning Activity
associated with Psychotherapies Lecture)



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Dr. Brenda Kirkby

Department of Physiology, Neuroscience, and Behavioral Sciences

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Learning Objective

SOM.MK.III.BPM2.4.NB.3.BEHS.0064 Identify the defense mechanism involved in a case scenario.

Defense Mechanisms

In psychoanalytic/psychodynamic theory, defense mechanisms are psychological strategies that people use to protect themselves from distress arising from unacceptable emotions, thoughts, or behaviors. Defenses (also known as ego defenses) are generally performed unconsciously and spontaneously. Some defenses are considered mature ways of dealing with internal conflict, while others are considered immature. However, even mature defenses may be maladaptive if used excessively.

The following table lists commonly used defense mechanisms and provides examples of each:

Defense Mechanism	Description	Examples
Acting Out	Expressing feelings through actions rather than words	An adolescent who is angry about their parents' divorce engages in vandalism and truancy A patient who has self-loathing thoughts engages in self-harm, such as cutting and burning themselves
Altruism ("ego-defensive altruism")	Performing a self-sacrificing act with a conscious altruistic intention but with an unconscious self-serving motivation	A person who feels guilty about not visiting their mother in a nursing home donates a large sum of money to the nursing home A parent who feels guilty about their child's death from drug overdose becomes a live kidney donor for a stranger who needs an organ transplant
Denial	Refusing to acknowledge or accept an unpleasant truth or reality	A person who has an obvious substance use problem refuses to admit having a substance use problem An individual who sustains a major injury denies the extent of their injury and continues to engage in activities that exacerbate their condition
Displacement	Redirecting one's emotions from its original source onto a less threatening target	A resident physician who is angry with their attending for unfair criticism is impatient and irritable with their patients A patient who is frustrated with the lack of progress in their medical treatment lashes out at family and friends

Defense Mechanism	Description	Examples
Dissociation	Mentally detaching oneself from a situation to cope with overwhelming emotions	A person who is in a car crash describes the event as unreal, like it is happening in a dream A person who is sexually assaulted disconnects from the experience by thinking about being in a happy place
Humor	Using humor (jokes, quips, laughter) to cope with difficult emotions or situations	A patient who is diagnosed with a psychiatric illness makes a humorous self-deprecating comment about mental illness A patient who loses hair from chemotherapy makes jokes about being bald
Identification	Adopting the characteristics or behaviors of another person to cope with feelings of inadequacy or insecurity	A medical student with high levels of self-doubt adopts the same mannerisms as their attending while interacting with patients A child who is being abused starts to talk and dress like a protective character from a movie
Intellectualization	Removing emotion from a thought or experience and replacing the emotion with excessive focus on intellectual aspects of the event	A person with chronic pain spends extensive time researching pain management techniques, medications, and their mechanisms of action and says, "I've read up on the pharmacokinetics of different analgesics and their impact on nerve pain." A person with newly diagnosed diabetes focuses on understanding the biochemical processes involved in blood sugar regulation and the specific mechanisms of insulin action and says, "I've been studying the glycemic index and how different foods affect insulin sensitivity. It's quite intricate."
Isolation of affect	Removing emotion from a thought or experience, describing the event in a detached, emotionless way	A person who experiences a traumatic event describes the details in a calm, detached manner without showing signs of emotional distress A patient who receives a cancer diagnosis tells family members of the diagnosis in a monotone, expressionless manner

Defense Mechanism	Description	Examples
Passive aggression	Expressing anger indirectly through passive or resistant behavior (lack of action)	A patient who is angry with their therapist shows up late to the next therapy session and fails to complete a prescribed therapy-related homework assignment An employee who is upset with their employer now works carelessly and inefficiently
Projection	Attributing one's own unwanted thoughts, traits, or emotions to someone else	A person who has a substance abuse problem accuses their friend of having a substance abuse problem A person who is frequently deceptive accuses their partner of being deceptive
Rationalization	Creating a logical, often self-serving, explanation to justify one's behaviors or feelings	A person who continues to smoke despite a chronic cough says, "Smoking helps me to relax, and stress is worse for my health than smoking." A patient who misses follow-up appointments for a serious medical condition provides the excuse of being too busy at work to take time off
Reaction Formation	Expressing the exact opposite of one's true feelings	A healthcare worker who lacks confidence in performing clinical skills overcompensates by acting overly assertive and domineering towards patients An elderly person who worries about age-related frailty and dependence engages in risky physical activities and boasts about their strength and energy
Regression	Displaying emotions, thoughts, or behaviors that are characteristic of an earlier stage of development	A patient who is hospitalized for surgery becomes demanding, irritable, and whiney with staff An adult who is arguing with their partner throws a tantrum, pouts, and sulks like a child
Repression	Forcing out of conscious awareness one's feelings, thoughts, or urges	An adult with a history of childhood abuse has no memory of the abuse A patient who undergoes emergency surgery does not remember the details of the event, including the pain and fear associated with the experience

Defense Mechanism	Description	Examples
Somatization	Expressing psychological distress through physical symptoms	A person who experiences significant emotional distress from relationships issues develops nausea, diarrhea, and abdominal pain A person who is chronically angry and frustrated in a demanding work environment develops chronic backpain related to emotional tension
Splitting	Categorizing experiences, people, or oneself as one of two opposing extremes (such as entirely good or entirely bad) to avoid feelings of ambivalence or uncertainty	A patient who experiences mild pain after a medical procedure describes the healthcare experience as entirely negative, disregarding any positive aspects of the procedure A patient who has multiple sclerosis alternates between viewing themselves as completely disabled and helpless or entirely capable and strong, depending on the day
Sublimation	Expressing distressful emotions or impulses through constructive, socially acceptable activities	A person whose partner dies of cancer expresses their grief by engaging in fundraising for cancer A person who is distraught about unreciprocated romantic feelings expresses their distress by writing poetry about their experience
Suppression	Consciously postponing the processing of distressing thoughts, emotions, or memories until a later time	A patient who receives a serious diagnosis chooses not to think about the diagnosis until after an upcoming family reunion A person who is dealing with the death of a loved one postpones grieving until immediate responsibilities of organizing the funeral and managing legal matters are completed

Test Your Knowledge
(Answers and explanations on next page)

- 1) A 33-year-old man comes to the physician because of a 3-month history of marital problems. He is convinced that his wife is cheating on him. He believes that many of her behaviors, like buying new clothes and talking on her cell phone, are evidence of her infidelity. The patient admits that he himself is having an affair with a co-worker and that his wife is not aware of his affair. Which of the following defense mechanisms best explains the patient's belief about his wife's infidelity?
 - A. Projection
 - B. Passive aggression
 - C. Rationalization
 - D. Identification
 - E. Denial

- 2) A 50-year-old man comes to the physician for a follow-up examination. He has been undergoing psychotherapy for the past 6 months for depressed mood and episodic rage. These negative emotions started after his wife of 25 years divorced him for another man. He initially expressed his anger by destroying his ex-wife's possessions and by lashing out at his children and friends. Most recently, he now gets out his emotions through completing a fulfilling house remodeling and landscaping project. Which of the following defense mechanisms best explains this patient's most recent way of coping with his negative emotions?
 - A. Splitting
 - B. Sublimation
 - C. Displacement
 - D. Suppression
 - E. Reaction formation

Answers and Explanations

- 1) A 33-year-old man comes to the physician because of a 3-month history of marital problems. He is convinced that his wife is cheating on him. He believes that many of her behaviors, like buying new clothes and talking on her cell phone, are evidence of her infidelity. The patient admits that he himself is having an affair with a co-worker and that his wife is not aware of his affair. Which of the following defense mechanisms best explains the patient's belief about his wife's infidelity?

A. Projection – Correct

This man gives ownership of his own attribute (infidelity) to his wife; he is thus using projection.

B. Passive aggression – Incorrect

Passive aggression involves indirect expressions of aggression towards a person and does not apply to this case.

C. Rationalization – Incorrect

Rationalization refers to generating a logical excuse for one's behaviors or feelings. This man is not justifying his infidelity, so rationalization is incorrect.

D. Identification – Incorrect

Identification refers to patterning one's behaviors after somebody else. He is not imitating his wife's behaviors, so identification is incorrect.

E. Denial – Incorrect

Denial refers to refusing to acknowledge or accept reality and does not apply to this case.

- 2) A 50-year-old man comes to the physician for a follow-up examination. He has been undergoing psychotherapy for the past 6 months for depressed mood and episodic rage. These negative emotions started after his wife of 25 years divorced him for another man. He initially expressed his anger by destroying his ex-wife's possessions and by lashing out at his children and friends. Most recently, he now gets out his emotions through completing a fulfilling house remodeling and landscaping project. Which of the following defense mechanisms best explains this patient's most recent way of coping with his negative emotions?

A. Choice A: Splitting – Incorrect

Splitting involves categorizing the world in polarized terms and does not apply to this case.

B. Choice B: Sublimation – Correct

This man initially displaced his anger (he took his anger toward his wife out on her possessions and their children and friends). Most recently, he expresses his emotions through working on a fulfilling project. Thus, he is now using sublimation as a coping strategy.

C. Choice C: Displacement

Displacement involves taking out emotions on a source other than the original source of the emotion. This man initially used displacement but now uses sublimation as a coping strategy.

D. Choice D: Suppression - Incorrect

Suppression involves temporary postponement of thinking about a situation and does not apply to this case.

E. Choice E: Reaction formation – Incorrect

Reaction formation refers to reacting exactly opposite to the way one feels and does not apply to this case.